Pakistan, a precipitous fall from the 44.7 per cent who endorsed talks just six months earlier. Pahalgam seems to have upended many of India's old certainties, particularly in the neighbourhood.

Strains in the Indo-US ties have prompted India to reaffirm its time-tested relations with Moscow and cautiously reopen diplomatic channels with China. In August, during a visit by Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi, national security advisor Ajit Doval officially announced PM Modi's participation in the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit in Tianjin, scheduled for August 31–September 1. Both sides are seeking to bring bilateral relations on track, with steps such as resuming the

33 PER CENT

Muslim respondents feel India was responsible for trade talks with US breaking down—highest among all religious groups

Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, reopening trade routes and restarting direct flights. Yet mistrust lingers. India's military establishment remains wary, recalling the 2020 Chinese incursions into eastern Ladakh. The public shares this caution. Asked to rank priorities in India's relationship with China, 56.5 per cent of respondents favour bolstering border security, while 22 per cent prioritise trade, a slight uptick from 53.3 per cent and 19.7 per cent, respectively, in February.

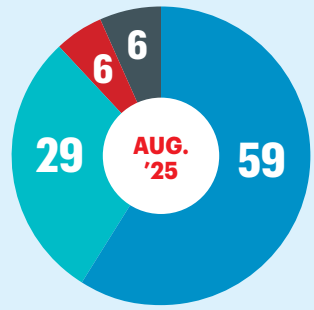
An Emerging Nexus

In a bid to rebuild trust, China has pledged to address three of India's pressing concerns: the supply of fertilisers, rare earth materials and tunnelboring machinery. These assurances are seen as confidence-building measures, underscoring a renewed attempt at pragmatic cooperation after years of frostiness. Indeed, India and China appear to be re-engaging in trade and diplomatic forums with cautious intent. Public opinion reflects this ambivalence. Asked about the implications of this thaw, 51.7 per cent of respondents say closer economic engagement with China will strengthens India's global position but 26.3 per cent worry it may come at the expense of national security.

Last month, Chief of Defence Staff Gen. Anil Chauhan warned that the growing strategic convergence between China, Pakistan and Bangladesh could carry significant consequences for regional stability and Indian security. His remark came weeks after Beijing hosted the first-ever trilateral meeting between the three countries on June 19. Each participant, experts contend, brings its own agenda to the table. China is keen to expand its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) projects and dilute India's influence in South Asia. Pakistan hopes to gain strategic access to Bangladesh, a potential staging ground for asymmetric warfare against India. For Dhaka, the prize lies in greater infrastructure investment and political backing from Beijing. Indians are cagey about this emerging nexus—47.8 per cent of respondents say they are 'very worried', another 23.7 per cent are 'somewhat worried'. Only 12.1 per cent appear not to be concerned.

The Opposition parties have been accusing the NDA government of diplomatic isolation following Op. Sindoor. Responding to the charge, PM Modi told Parliament that only three of the 193 United Nations member states supported Pakistan. The rest, he said, supported India's war on terror, the BRICS bloc among them. Most MOTN respondents support the government's claim, with 66.7 saying India's global standing has improved under the NDA, although this marks a slight dip from 72.6 per cent in February. Dissent has edged up too: 27.4 per cent now question the effectiveness of India's diplomacy, compared to 25.4 per cent earlier this year. On a broader measure of global influence, 60 per cent feel India's global esteem has risen in recent years, while 21.7 per cent believe it remains unchanged. Only 14.5 per cent say it has declined. ■

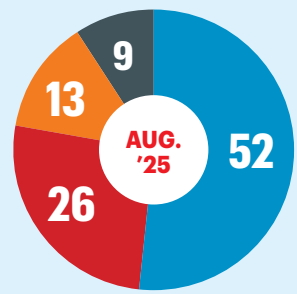
Q. If the United States increases political or military support to Pakistan, how should India respond?



Strengthen ties with other allies such as Russia
Increase military readiness
Seek dialogue with Pakistan
DK/ CS

A majority recommend leaning on traditional allies like Russia

Q. Recent reports suggest India and China are engaging more closely in certain trade and diplomatic forums. How do you view this for India?



Strengthening India's position globally
Weakening India's security interests
No significant impact
DK/ CS

The majority feel India will be stronger globally if it aligns with China

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/CS: Don't know/can't say